

possibility that the data you carry on the drive will be shared, so all programs must work with all common file formats, where applicable.

And so begins the hunt.

The Office Suite

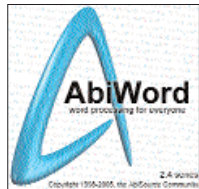
While there are plenty of office suites out there that could even fit on a floppy disk, hardly any of them have support for the ubiquitous .doc format, leaving only one choice: Portable OpenOffice.org. Right from its excellent support for all common MS Office formats, to its MS Office-like interface that ensures that its users don't feel like lost sheep, Portable OpenOffice.org is the office suite you want to carry around with you. It weighs in at 144 MB, taking up a huge chunk of our limit, but when you consider that it gives you practically everything that your current 500+ MB (and very expensive) installation of MS Office does, it's worth it.



If all you need is something to write and to edit documents on, the 15 MB AbiWord is one alternative worth considering

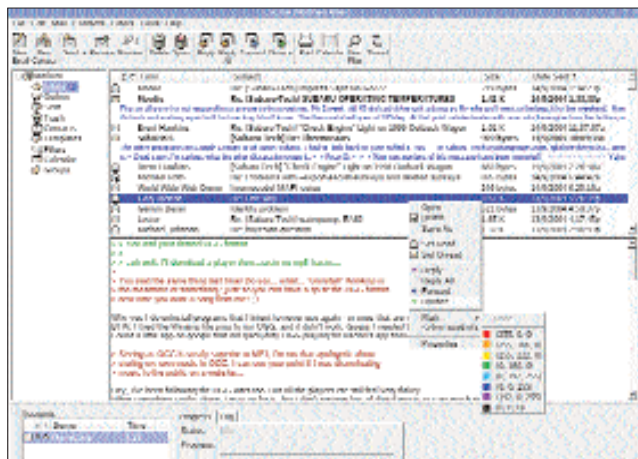
The Word Processor

There are loads of people who install whole office suites where a program or two would have sufficed, but even if you don't need an entire gaggle of office applications, you will need a good word processor—enter Portable AbiWord. AbiWord has a look and feel similar to Microsoft Word's, and offers nearly the same features. So if all you need is something to write and to edit documents on, this 15 MB alternative is one worth considering.



The E-Mail Client

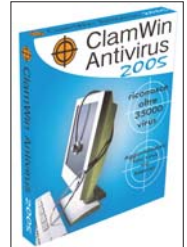
On one hand, there's i.Scribe, a small, seemingly simple e-mail client that fills up only 1 MB of space. It even comes with its own Bayesian spam filter, and is extremely light on system resources. It's a stripped-down version of a commercial product called InScribe, and is limited to only one user profile and one user filter.



At the other end of the spectrum is Portable Thunderbird, which brings to the USB all the features of Mozilla Thunderbird—e-mail, internal support for RSS feeds, a spam filter and a spell-checker. On the flip side, it occupies 9 MB.

The Anti-Virus

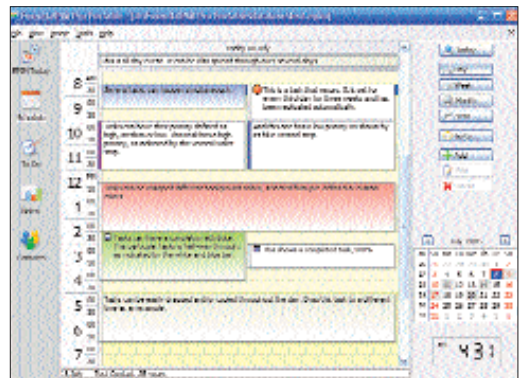
Now you *could* be safe in assuming that you're connecting your USB drive to a clean PC, but it never hurts to carry an anti-virus with you—just in case. ClamWin is a free, open source, 18 MB anti-virus that comes from the ClamAV team, who have been developing the Clam anti-virus engine since the days of DOS. Getting it to work off a USB drive does take some time though. You need to first install it to your current PC and follow the instructions in the manual to set it up for USB drives. Luckily for you, we've done the dirty work, and you'll find a ZIP file on this month's CD, which you just need to extract to your USB drive.



Remember, it isn't a real-time or on-access scanner, so you will need to start the program and choose the file/s you want to scan.

The PIM

For busy individuals who need to keep track of their tasks and schedules, EssentialPIM is a very useful Personal Information Manager (PIM), which looks a little like Outlook's PIM side. You can use it to create to-do lists, schedule meetings and appointments, manage contacts, and leave little notes to yourself—just as you would do in Outlook, and the famil-



Some Homework

There are applications that boast about being portable, and then there are more modest applications that don't talk about it so much. For example, you'd think that Winamp would be tied to one PC at a time, right? Copy the Winamp program folder to a USB stick and try to run it from a PC that doesn't have Winamp, and surprise, surprise—it's portable! So if you're ever in the mood, go ahead and see if a program you need is portable. And tell us about it, too!